

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF NEW YORK

-----X
JAMEL ELLISON,

Plaintiff,

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK; Police Officer MICHAEL
TANSEY, Shield No. 3902, individually and in his/her
official capacities; and NYPD Officers JOHN and JANE
DOE 1 through 10, individually and in their official
capacities (the names John and Jane Doe being fictitious,
as the true names are presently unknown),

Defendants.

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SUMMONS

Jury Trial Demanded

Plaintiff designates New
York County as the place
of trial.

The basis of venue is:
CPLR § 504(3)

To the above named Defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the Complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the Complaint is not served with this Summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorney within 20 days after the service of this Summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the Complaint.

Dated: NEW YORK, NEW YORK
December 18, 2017

Katherine E. Smith, Esq.
LAW OFFICE OF K.E. SMITH
233 Broadway, Ste. 1800
New York, New York 10279
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TO:

ZACHARY W. CARTER
Corporation Counsel of the City of New York
Attorney for Defendant THE CITY OF NEW YORK
100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

Police Officer MICHAEL TANSEY, Shield No. 3902; Warrant Section 300 Gold Street
Brooklyn NY 11201

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PLAINTIFF JAMEL ELLISON, by his attorneys, LAW OFFICE OF KATHERINE E. SMITH, complaining of the defendants, respectfully alleges as follows:

FACTS

1. PLAINTIFF JAMEL ELLISON, is an African American male and has been at all relevant times a resident of New York County in the City and State of New York.
2. Defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, was and is a municipal corporation duly organized and existing under and by virtue of the laws of the State of New York.
3. Defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, maintains the New York City Police Department, duly authorized public authorities and/or police departments, authorized to perform all functions of a police department as per the applicable sections of the New York State

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

Jury Trial Demanded

Index No.

BASIS FOR VENUE:

CPLR § 504(3)

Criminal Procedure Law, acting under the direction and supervision of the aforementioned municipal corporation, The City of New York.

4. At all times relevant defendants Police Officer MICHAEL TANSEY, Shield No. 3902, and NYPD Defendants John & Jane Doe 1 through 10 (“Doe Defendants”) were police officers, detectives or supervisors employed by the NYPD. PLAINTIFF does not know the real names and shield / tax numbers of defendants John & Jane Doe 1 through 10.

5. That at all times hereinafter mentioned the defendants, either personally or through their employees, were acting under color of state law and/or in compliance with the official rules, regulations, laws, statutes, customs, usages and/or practices of the State or City of New York.

6. Each and all of the acts of the defendants alleged herein were done by said defendants while acting within the scope of their employment by defendant THE CITY OF NEW YORK.

7. Each and all of the acts of the defendants alleged herein were done by said defendants while acting in furtherance of their employment by defendant THE CITY OF NEW YORK.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

8. Plaintiff has been systematically harrassed by the New York City Police Department and falsely arrested, *inter alia*, for engaging in activities that are protected under the First Amendment

9. Indeed, plaintiff is a musician and on August 20, 2015, at approximately 3:50 p.m., was lawfully in the vicinity of 736 7th Avenue, New York, NY he was lawfully distributing compact discs that contained his own original music, which is protected under the

First Amendment.

10. Without provocation, several New York City Police Officers, including defendant TANSEY, approached plaintiff and placed him under arrest despite the fact that DEFENDANTS lacked probable cause to believe that they had any committed any crimes or offenses, the defendants placed plaintiff under arrest.

11. Plaintiff was transported to a police precinct where he learned that he was being charged with committing Disorderly Conduct (PL 240.20(5) and Aggressive Begging in a Public Place AC 10.136(b)(1).

12. At the precinct, the officers, including defendant TANSEY, falsely informed employees of the New York County District Attorney's Office ("DA's Office") that they had observed PLAINTIFF commit various crimes/offenses.

13. Neither TANSEY, nor the DOE defendants observed PLAINTIFF violate any laws / ordinances.

14. The allegations made by Defendants to the DA's Office were false, and the defendants knew them to be false at the time the defendants made the allegations.

15. The defendants then forwarded these false allegations to the DA's Office in order to justify the unlawful arrest of PLAINTIFF and to persuade the DA's Office to commence and/or continue the criminal prosecution of PLAINTIFF.

16. The defendants knew and understood that the DA's Office was relying on the truthfulness of defendant's claims and statements in order to evaluate whether to commence a criminal prosecution against the PLAINTIFF. Defendants were aware that the DA's Office assumed that all of the factual statements, claims and allegations that defendants relayed to the

DA's Office were truthful in all material respects.

17. From the precinct, PLAINTIFF was then transported to Central Booking and was arraigned thereafter.

18. PLAINTIFF appeared in court as required, the case was taken to trial. On July 27, 2016, PLAINTIFF was acquitted of all charges.

19. PLAINTIFF suffered damage as a result of defendants' actions. PLAINTIFF was deprived of liberty, suffered emotional distress, mental anguish, fear, pain, bodily injury, anxiety, embarrassment, humiliation, and reputational damage.

FIRST CLAIM
UNDER N.Y. STATE and FEDERAL LAW
FALSE ARREST/IMPRISONMENT

20. PLAINTIFF repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in the preceding paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

21. Defendant police officers arrested PLAINTIFF in the absence of probable cause and without a valid warrant.

22. As a result of the aforesaid conduct by defendants, PLAINTIFF was subjected to an illegal, improper and false arrest by the defendants and caused to be falsely imprisoned, detained and confined. The aforesaid actions by the defendants constituted a deprivation of the plaintiff's rights.

23. As a result of the foregoing false imprisonment, PLAINTIFF's liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, PLAINTIFF was put in fear for PLAINTIFF's safety, was humiliated and subjected to handcuffing and other physical restraints.

24. PLAINTIFF was conscious of said confinement and did not consent to same.

25. The confinement of PLAINTIFF was without probable cause and was not otherwise privileged.

26. As a result of the aforementioned conduct, PLAINTIFF has suffered physical and mental injury, together with embarrassment, humiliation, shock, fright and loss of freedom.

SECOND CLAIM
UNDER N.Y. STATE LAW AND FEDERAL LAW
MALICIOUS ABUSE OF PROCESS

27. PLAINTIFF repeats and re-alleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

28. The individual defendants issued legal process to place PLAINTIFF under arrest.

29. The Municipal Defendants arrested PLAINTIFF in order to obtain collateral objectives outside the legitimate ends of the legal process.

30. The Municipal Defendants acted with intent to do harm to PLAINTIFF without excuse or justification.

31. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, PLAINTIFF sustained, *inter alia*, loss of liberty, loss of earnings, emotional distress, mental anguish, shock, fright, apprehension, embarrassment, humiliation, deprivation of constitutional rights, in addition to the damages hereinbefore alleged.

THIRD CLAIM
UNDER N.Y. STATE AND FEDERAL LAW
MALICIOUS PROSECUTION

32. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

33. By their conduct, as described herein, defendants are liable to PLAINTIFF for having committed malicious prosecution under the laws of the State of New York.

34. Defendants maliciously commenced criminal proceeding against PLAINTIFF. Defendants falsely and without probable cause charged PLAINTIFF with violations of the laws of the State of New York.

35. The commencement and continuation of the criminal proceedings against PLAINTIFF was malicious and without probable cause.

36. All charges were terminated in PLAINTIFF's favor.

37. PLAINTIFF suffered post-arraignment deprivation of freedom: he was remanded to Rikers Island where he remained for approximately five (5) days and he was required to attend many court appearances to defense against the criminal charges.

38. Defendants, their officers, agents, servants and employees were responsible for the malicious prosecution of PLAINTIFF. Defendant City of New York, as an employer of the individual defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat superior.

39. As a direct and proximate result of the misconduct and abuse of authority stated above, PLAINTIFF sustained the damages alleged herein.

FOURTH CLAIM
UNDER FEDERAL LAW
DEPRIVATION OF FEDERAL RIGHTS

40. PLAINTIFF repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in the preceding paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

41. All of the aforementioned acts of defendants, their agents, servants and employees, were carried out under the color of state law.

42. All of the aforementioned acts deprived PLAINTIFF of the rights, privileges and immunities guaranteed to citizens of the United States by the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States of America, and in violation of 42 U.S.C. § 1983.

43. The acts complained of were carried out by the aforementioned individual defendants in their capacities as police officers with all the actual and/or apparent authority attendant thereto.

44. The acts complained of were carried out by the aforementioned individual defendants in their capacities as police officers, pursuant to the customs, usages, practices, procedures, and the rules of the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, all under the supervision of ranking officers of said department.

45. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, engaged in conduct which constituted a custom, usage, practice, procedure or rule of the respective municipality/authority, which is forbidden by the Constitution of the United States.

FIFTH CLAIM
UNDER FEDERAL LAW
DENIAL OF CONSTITUTIONAL RIGHT TO FAIR TRIAL

46. PLAINTIFF repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in the preceding paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

47. Defendants created false evidence against PLAINTIFF.

48. Defendants forwarded false evidence and false information to prosecutors in the New York County District Attorney office.

49. Defendants misled the prosecutors by creating false evidence against PLAINTIFF and thereafter providing false testimony throughout the criminal proceedings.

50. In creating false evidence against PLAINTIFF, in forwarding false evidence and information to prosecutors, and in providing false and misleading sworn statements, defendants violated PLAINTIFF's constitutional right to a fair trial under the Sixth Amendment and the Due Process Clause of the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

51. As a result of the foregoing, PLAINTIFF's liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, he was put in fear for his safety, and he was humiliated and subjected to handcuffing and other physical restraints without probable cause.

SIXTH CLAIM
UNDER NEW YORK STATE AND FEDERAL LAW
UNLAWFUL STOP, SEARCH, AND SEIZURE

52. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

53. As a result of the aforesaid conduct by defendants, PLAINTIFF's person and possessions were illegally and improperly seized and searched without consent, a valid warrant, probable cause, privilege or consent, in violation of his constitutional rights as set forth in the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

SEVENTH CLAIM
UNDER FEDERAL LAW
FIRST AMENDMENT RETALIATION

54. Plaintiffs repeat and reallege each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

55. By their conduct, as described herein, and acting under color of state law to deprive the plaintiffs of their right to freedom of speech under the First and Fourteenth Amendments, the individual defendants are liable for violation of 42 U.S.C. § 1983 which prohibits the deprivation under color of state law of rights secured under the United States Constitution.

56. The individual defendants have violated plaintiffs' First them to false arrest and excessive force to deter the exercise of his First Amendment rights. Defendants' actions were taken in retaliation for plaintiffs exercising their First Amendment rights.

57. As a consequence of the individual defendants' actions, plaintiffs have suffered violations of their First and Fourteenth Amendment rights to free speech.

58. Plaintiffs suffer fear and apprehension that they will, again, be subject to similar unlawful acts by defendants done for the purpose of limiting and preventing their First Amendment-protected activities.

59. As a direct and proximate result of the individual defendants' unlawful actions, plaintiffs have suffered damages including, physical, mental and emotional injury and pain, mental anguish, suffering, humiliation, embarrassment and loss of reputation.

EIGHTH CLAIM
UNDER FEDERAL LAW
FAILURE TO INTERVENE

60. Plaintiffs repeat and reallege each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

61. Those defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct observed such conduct, had an opportunity prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct and failed to intervene.

62. Accordingly, the defendants who failed to intervene violated the First, Fourth, Fifth And Fourteenth Amendments.

63. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiffs sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

NINTH CLAIM
UNDER N.Y. STATE AND FEDERAL LAW
MUNICIPAL LIABILITY

64. PLAINTIFF repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in the preceding paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

65. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, engaged in conduct that constituted a custom, usage, practice, procedure or rule of the respective municipality/authority, which is forbidden by the Constitution of the United States.

66. The aforementioned customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York and the New York City Police Department include, but are not limited to, the following unconstitutional practices:

- i. arresting individuals regardless of probable cause in order to inflate the officer's arrest statistics; and,
- ii. arresting innocent persons notwithstanding the existence of credible evidence which exonerates the accused of any criminal wrongdoing; and,
- iii. fabricating evidence in connection with their prosecution in order to cover up police misconduct; and,
- iv. fabricating evidence in connection with search warrants in order to effectuate otherwise illegal searches and seizures, and,
- v. fabricating evidence in connection with search warrants in order to cover up police misconduct.

67. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City

of New York and the New York City Police Department constituted deliberate indifference to the safety, well-being and constitutional rights of the PLAINTIFF.

68. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York and the New York City Police Department were the direct and proximate cause of the constitutional violations suffered by the PLAINTIFF as alleged herein.

69. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York and the New York City Police Department were the moving force behind the constitutional violations suffered by the PLAINTIFF as alleged herein.

70. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, were directly and actively involved in violating the PLAINTIFF's constitutional rights.

71. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, acquiesced in a pattern of unconstitutional conduct by subordinate police officers, and were directly responsible for the violation of the PLAINTIFF's constitutional rights.

72. The acts complained of deprived the PLAINTIFF of his right:

- A. Not to be deprived of liberty without due process of law;
- B. To be free from seizure and arrest not based upon probable cause;
- C. Not to have summary punishment imposed upon him; and
- D. To receive equal protection under the law.

DATED: New York, New York
December 18, 2017

_____/s/_____
Katherine E. Smith
233 Broadway, Ste. 1800
New York, New York 10279
Tel/ Fax: 347-470-3707
ksmith@legalsmithny.com
Attorney for Plaintiff

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

KATHERINE E. SMITH, an attorney duly admitted to practice law in the Courts of the State of New York, shows:

That she is a member of THE LAW OFFICE OF KATHERINE E. SMITH the attorneys for PLAINTIFF Jamel Ellison in the within entitled action.

That your deponent has read the foregoing **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and knows the contents thereof, and that the same is true to her own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters, she believes it to be true.

That the source of the deponent's information are investigation and records in the file.

That the reason why the verification is made by deponent and not by the PLAINTIFF is that the PLAINTIFF is not within the county wherein deponent maintains his office.

Deponent affirms that the foregoing statements are true under the penalties of perjury.

Dated: New York, New York
December 18, 2017

_____/S/_____
Katherine E. Smith